Fighting Sleep

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Rape/Non-Con, Underage

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Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Incest, Suicidal Thoughts, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Angst with a Happy Ending, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Insomnia

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Fighting Sleep

by Paganaidd

Summary

Adora was ready to die to save Etheria.
She didn't.
Now she has to make a new life for herself.

But it's difficult when she can't sleep.

Chapter 1

“Adora. Quit.” Catra was glad this bed was so much bigger than their bunks in the Cadet barracks had been. It hadn’t been uncommon for Adora to kick Catra off the bed when she was sleep-fighting. On the other hand, Catra would be able to retreat to the upper bunk when her friend was restless. Here, there was only the floor if she wanted to get away from the other woman’s thrashing.

The blonde woman flopped over again muttering and making distressed noises. Great. More nightmares. “Wake up, you’re having a bad dream .” Catra shook her firmly.

Adora sat bolt upright, her eyes wide open, staring straight ahead into the darkness. She reached out her hand and the room lit with thaumaturgic power, temporarily blinding Catra’s sensitive dark-adjusted eyes.

“Adora!” yelped Catra, diving to the floor, not wanting to get in the way if her partner mistakenly took a swing with the sword.

It took a few seconds for the light dazzle to clear from her vision: when Catra could finally see, She-Ra stood on the bed. It was not the sword she held, but a staff. On top of the staff, a bright crystal glowed, lighting the room more brightly than daylight. Holding it high, she peered into the corners of as if looking for enemies hidden behind the soft furnishings and drapery.

Slowly, Catra got to her feet, making sure to keep her hands in sight. “Hey, Adora?”

“C-Catra?” Adora’s eyes seemed to focus. Maybe she was properly awake now. “Shadow Weaver...? Where is she?” Or maybe not. “Her shadow-spy things were here!”

“Shadow Weaver’s dead, Adora. I think you were just dreaming.” Catra tried for a neutral, calming tone. “Remember?”

“Oh.” SheRa flickered and disappeared, leaving only Adora standing on the bed in her nightclothes. She fell to her knees and uttered a low keening wail.

Catra crept onto their bed and reached out to gather the weeping woman into her arms. “It’s okay. I’m here,” she whispered.

Adora recoiled as if Catra had struck her, her lip curled with something that looked like...disgust? “Don’t,” she whimpered. She swallowed with an audible gulp, as though she was fighting not to vomit, then slid off the bed and ran to the bathroom. The door slammed shut and Catra heard a click. For the first time ever, Adora locked a door between them.

“The fuck?” Catra jumped up to pound on the door. “Adora?” Over the sound of the shower running, Catra heard painful hiccuping sobs. “Come on, open the door!” she pleaded in time to her banging. Adora had never looked at her that way before, not ever. Even on their worst day she had never shrunk from Catra as if she were something filthy.

Melog appeared in the room, their mane dark and jagged. “Can you unlock this?” Catra demanded. She retained enough common sense to realize breaking the door was not a good idea.

The magical creature growled and the latched door swung open. Steam flowed out of the bathroom in thick clouds. Adora sat on the floor of the shower, her head on her knees, still in the shirt she slept in, her skin bright red and raw. Alarmed, Catra reached out and shut off the water. “What the fuck, Adora?”

Wet blonde hair swayed as Adora shook her head without looking up. Catra snagged a towel and bent down, intending to wrap it around her.

“Don’t touch me.” Adora flinched and put her hand up between them. Her voice was thick with tears and unnaturally high pitched. “Please. Just...just leave me alone.”

The promise Catra had made to Adora on Darla came back to her, "If you ever want me to go, I'll go," she'd said. Was that what was happening? She backed out of the room, unsure of what to do. This was way out of her experience.

"Do you think I did something?" she whispered to Melog.

Her friend shook their head. "She speaks not to you. The Dark One" that had been Melog's name for Shadow Weaver, "still lives in her mind."

Of course she does. "So, what should I do?"

"Stay with her," they mewled. "She should not be alone."

Stay with her? Right. Catra could do that. "Hey, Adora?" she said softly as she went back into the room. "It's only me. I'll just sit here, Okay?" She sat down on the floor, opposite the shower. "I won't touch you and you don't have to say anything, but Melog says you shouldn't be alone. I'll stay with you."

"Promise?" Adora gasped out, still crying.

"I promise." Catra ached to put her arms around Adora and she felt useless just sitting here, but she could understand feeling so scared that even the most innocuous touches felt like threats to be met with deadly force.

They sat like that until Adora's sobs quieted. The cool breeze coming through the open window smelled like dry leaves and woodsmoke. Adora began to shiver. Rolling her eyes, Catra took the towel and threw it at her. "You're freezing. You should dry off. At least take off your wet clothes."

Adora nodded. Without saying anything or even looking at Catra she pulled her shirt off and wrapped up in the towel. She still shivered. Slowly, it came to Catra that it wasn't just cold that made Adora shake. Her skin was still bright red, almost like sunburn and that water had been *hot* .

“Um, Adora? Did you hurt yourself?”

“I’ll be fine.” Adora squared her shoulders and took a long breath. It seemed like whatever had happened was passing. She scrubbed at her face with the towel. “I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to upset you. I think it was just a bad dream.” She stood, using the oversized towel to cover as much of her skin as she could, almost as if she wanted to hide it from Catra. “Can we...just go back to bed?”

“You are a shitty liar,” Catra growled. “Five minutes ago you freaked out when I touched you.” The look on Adora’s face had been as if something slimy had crawled on her and Catra couldn’t keep the hurt out of her voice. “If...if you want me to get out or go sleep somewhere else...I will,” her voice sank to a murmur. “But,” she continued more loudly, “I will go scrounge up Arrow Boy and Sparkles and get them to sit with you.”

“No. I don’t want to talk to either of them about this.” Adora’s shoulders slumped and she pulled the towel more tightly around herself.

“So...you want me to stay?” Catra checked.

“Please?” At last, she looked at Catra, “Don’t...don’t leave me.” Her eyes were filled with tears again and her shakes hadn’t stopped.

“Can I come over there?” Catra was beginning to suspect Adora was going into shock or something.

“Y-yes?”

“Okay.” Catra took a step forward and picked up a second towel from the rack on the wall. “Can I touch you now?” Adora nodded and let Catra wrap her shoulders with it, then guide her back into the bedroom with a gentle arm on her shoulder, but Catra did not miss the barely suppressed wince at even that contact. “You want me to get you dry clothes?” she asked.

"Yeah." Adora's body still shook as she climbed back into bed and pulled the covers up.

Cautiously, Catra crawled in beside her and handed her the dry shirt and shorts. Adora tossed the wet towels onto the floor and pulled them on with unsteady fingers. "I'm sorry," she said.

Catra put her head on the pillow and patted the space beside her. Adora lay down facing her.

"So...uh...do you remember what you were dreaming about?" Catra asked.

"Do you remember when Shadow Weaver was going to erase my memory? I mean the day I tried to rescue Glimmer? When you gave me back the sword."

Really, it would be great if Catra *could* forget things like that. "Yeah. Is that what you were dreaming about?"

"Maybe." Adora shook her head, her expression pensive. "I'm not sure. I just remember little bits. Shadow Weaver's mask and hearing her voice. We were in the Black Garnet chamber."

She bit her lip. "I don't think it was that time with Glimmer. I was talking to Shadow Weaver by myself. I was so scared. I'm not sure why. I think I was afraid for you? Or maybe you were in trouble and I was trying to talk her into going easy on you?"

So, pretty much any ordinary day in the Fright Zone.

"Were you dreaming about Shadow Weaver...punishing you?" Catra could never remember Adora being punished by Shadow Weaver with more than a harsh word, but who knows what the old witch had done when they were alone. That might be the reason *why* it never took more than a harsh word.

"Did she..?" Adora's voice trailed off, as if afraid to articulate the question. She gulped a quick gasping breath, firming her resolve to put the unthinkable into words. "She did it before. Messed with

my memories, I mean." Not a question this time, just a bald statement of fact.

Catra's stomach dropped. She hesitated, closed her eyes and breathed deeply. Adora needed her honesty. "Yeah. Probably."

For a few seconds, they both were silent, trying to process this thing they both agreed was probably real. "Do you have any idea why?"

"I don't know, honestly. I remember that, every so often, you'd disappear for an afternoon with Shadow Weaver. Then you'd need me to tell you about what we were supposed to be studying. I remember having to teach you multiplication tables a couple of times. You'd be weird and jumpy for days. You wouldn't let me out of your sight and you'd usually ask me to sleep with you for a few weeks."

That curl of Adora's lip again; the expression of someone who'd found a maggot wriggling in their food; just as quickly it was gone. She pressed her lips together and squeezed her eyes shut. After a second she moaned in frustration and covered her face with her hands. "I don't know. I almost feel like I'm trying to get around some mental block. I mean, I know *something's* there, and it's...terrible."

"Of course it's terrible," Catra mused, out loud. "Shadow Weaver was terrible. ″ Very carefully, Catra reached out to touch Adora's shoulder. She purred with relief when Adora moved forward to rest her chin on the top of Catra's head.

Gradually, Adora's body relaxed as Catra snuggled against her, but sleep was lost cause for Catra tonight. They hadn't spoken much about the things that had happened before or during the War. They both understood that those conversations were coming, but they had so much to unpack that Catra had no idea where to even begin.

For all her bravado, Catra knew she had never defied Shadow Weaver's will before the day she let Adora and the Princess escape. Until then she'd rebelled against Shadow Weaver only in small ways. When she was still a cadet, she skipped classes, slept in and made a great show of her back talk and arrogance. After her promotion, it was more of the same, but the reality was Catra never crossed Shadow Weaver in any way that counted. At the time, Catra told herself she had defied Shadow Weaver and given the sword back to Adora because she didn't want to lose her position. To be fair, that was certainly part of it. Now, thinking back, she could admit that the larger part was the broken expression on Adora's face and the yawning chasm of terror it opened inside Catra's gut.

Run, Just Run

Chapter Summary

Adora goes for a run.

TW for possibly implied self-harm

Familiar thoughts swarmed and multiplied in Adora's head, competing with the pounding of her feet, and the rhythmic pumping of her legs. She had hoped that with the war's end, the thoughts would have gone away, but they never did.

I shouldn't be here.
I was supposed to die.

Running always felt right. The thoughts and the cringing horror that accompanied them could usually be outrun if she ran long enough and hard enough.

Why didn't I die?
I was supposed to die.

Today was going to have to be very long. Biting her lip, she quickened her pace, sweat soaking through her shirt and dripping into her eyes. The thoughts dogged her heels, reminding her of her many failures. It would be so much easier to make the thoughts stop if they weren't true.

I'm so tired.

She tried not to think too hard about the freak-out she had last night and the superficial burns she'd given herself. If Catra had noticed them, she had not said anything about it.

I can't be like this.
I can't be tired
People still need me.

Not me. People need She Ra.
I can't be like this.

Adora still could not remember much of the dream. Still, she did remember the skin-crawling sensation of utter filthiness she had as if she'd been dropped into the Fright Zone's sewers without Mermista's magical abilities. She wanted to scrub her skin off, and she'd welcomed the stinging agony of the scalding water. If Catra had not turned the water off, Adora would have stayed there for much longer.

What's wrong with me? We won. I should be happy.

She tried to change her focus, to think of her friends. Glimmer, Bow, Catra. Sometimes it helped. Today it did not. Catra's glowing green eyes filled her mind.

She was afraid at the end. And she suffered.

"Stop," she muttered out loud to herself. "Just stop. I'm doing my best."

If your best were good enough, Angella would still be here.

Adora put on a burst of speed as she raced the thoughts down the hill. Gritting her teeth, she tried to suppress the images that went with the thoughts.

Angella's last sad smile. Glimmer's despair.

But we won, she reminded herself*. Catra is safe. Glimmer is safe. Bow is safe.*

Etheria is safe.

But for how long?

The last conversation she'd ever had with Shadow Weaver replayed in her mind again. She remembered slapping Shadow Weaver's hand from her shoulder and shouting, "You ruin people!

You ruin any chance they have to ever be happy. I will never forgive you.” The very next time Adora saw her, Shadow Weaver had died to save her and Catra.

Adora still could not bring herself to forgive the sorceress, but the parallels between Shadow Weaver’s death and Angella’s were obvious.

Both of them died because She Ra failed. And because She Ra failed, Etheria had to fight Horde Prime.

The thought of Horde Prime led back to the thought of her friends' suffering. The way Glimmer’s hands shook when she spoke his name, and the way Catra turned her claws on herself when the world started to feel unreal.

Sweat (or was it tears?) clouded Adora’s vision as she ran downhill on the dirt trail. Her foot came down on the uneven ground, and her ankle turned, her knee wrenched, and she tried to tuck into a roll, but the gravel met her forehead and one outstretched hand.

Fortunately, no one was around to see her tumble; no one came running to answer her involuntary shriek. She lay still for a moment, curled around the hurt, gritting her teeth, breathing around the cries that tried to fight their way up from her lungs, the way she had been taught, the way she had done all of her life. No matter how much it hurt, she knew it would be so much worse if she showed the pain. If she could not stop the tears, at least no one was around to see.

After a while, the nausea passed enough for her to sit up. The movement sent agony into her ankle; she could feel the crunching of bone on bone. The knee of her leggings was torn and bloody. Her hand bled sluggishly as she brushed off the road grit embedded in the abrasions. Livid red and purple bruises bloomed up and down her arm.

It didn’t matter, though. She reached out and summoned her sword to invoke She Ra’s healing magic. The golden light left her

skin smooth and unmarked. The nausea and dizziness abated. All that was left of the spill was her torn and bloody leggings. Hopefully, she could slip in before her partner woke up. The magicat was feeling much better, but Adora did not want to stress her out.

Thinking about Catra's illness made Adora tear up again. What was wrong with her? Everything was making her lose it today. She leaned her forehead against her knees, wrapping her arms around them. Alone in the morning light, she gave in to the tears and let the crying jag run its course. At least out here, she wasn't worrying everyone with her hysterics.

It was a long time before she pulled herself back together. Gingerly she stood, testing her weight on her ankle. It hurt, but she could suck it up and finish her run. Shifting to She Ra healed her wounds, but the pain stayed. It made sense; how could she learn to avoid injury if the healing magic made the pain go away completely? So what if her head still hurt (yes, she'd probably had a little concussion), and her wrist and ankle ached with the deep burn of the magical healing? That was fine, it would abate soon enough. A day, maybe three, and the pain of the wounds would fade from her flesh.

The thoughts that had been plaguing her all morning were silent now. Her mind was a merciful void as she pounded back toward home.

Soul ties

Chapter Summary

Micah and Melog bond

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the delay. Now that I have finished the other stories necessary for this one, I can work on this again!

Be warned: My updating schedule is always going to be erratic.

Micah retired to his solitary room, knowing sleep was going to be elusive, but he could not face the holiday merriment with Angella's loss so raw. This was the first holiday he had spent without at least the hope that he would see her again.

After his rescue from Beast Island, he had no time to mourn. With the loss of She Ra and the Sword of Protection, they stood no chance against Prime's forces. They had to evacuate Bright Moon in a matter of days after Prime's invasion.

Shadow fucking Weaver had been very vocal about her opinion of who was at fault. needling the girl about breaking She Ra's sword. The old witch was furious and let everyone know that Adora had failed them but in the softest possible tones, often under cover of concern. "Are you sure you should ask that of her? She's not as strong as she once was," the dark sorceress had murmured to Micah whenever Adora volunteered for anything. "And the Queen did have questions about her judgment and decisions."

Finally, before a war council meeting, Micah called the old bitch out for the snide comments. People looked up to Adora, even without She Ra. The only thing Shadow Weaver was accomplishing was ruining the rebel morale.

The sorceress crossed her arms against her chest and tilted her head. “Perhaps you would not be so eager to put so much faith in her if you knew how her mistakes led to your wife’s death.”

Unfortunately, Adora arrived just in time to overhear, as Shadow Weaver no doubt intended. The girl fled from the meeting. Afterward, Bow approached Micah to tell him what details he knew.

So, for months, Micah never had a chance to grieve or really even think of his wife. While he held the Rebellion together, his thoughts were all with his daughter. When he was chipped, Prime followed the threads to discover who he cared for and used that information to torment, but Prime never invoked Angella’s image.

Now, without the pressure of simply surviving, Micah found he had time to think about Angella. It hurt. He poured himself a glass of wine and sat in front of his fire. “Ah, dammit, Angie,” he muttered, staring at the play of light on the crystal goblet.

Somebody knocked on his door, probably his sister coming to check on him.

“Thanks, Casta, but I’m okay,“ he said, even before he fully opened the door. He stopped, suddenly wrong-footed. “Umm… Hello?” Rather than his sister, a giant, blue-maned catlike creature sat in front of his door.

The thing shook their translucent blue mane and trilled.

“Is-is there something I can help you with?” Micah asked, feeling a little ridiculous to speak to it as though it understood but mindful of what his sister had told him about Catra’s friend. Castaspella had told Micah that Melog was not a familiar or pet but was more akin to a magical guardian. Fully sentient in its own right, albeit their thinking was somewhat alien, and thus was due all the courtesy of any of Mystacor’s guests. “Would you like to come in?”

It nodded and stood up, pacing into the room at the invitation. It floated into Micah's mind that maybe the creature was alone tonight because their young one was busy.

They considered Catra to be their young one. That was intriguing. Also intriguing was the way the creature communicated without words. He had heard that Catra was the only one who could understand their actual language, but apparently, Melog could make themselves understood if they chose.

"Can I get you anything?" Micah asked. The creature shook their head and settled in front of the fire as if it were theirs and theirs alone. That made Micah laugh out loud-- it was such a *cat* thing to do. Even more so when the magical feline gave him a look of reproach at the laughter.

The man closed the door and resumed his chair. Melog put their head down, watching Micah and purring.

The silent companionship was pleasant. Sometimes talking and being talked to was overwhelming. Micah sipped on his drink and stared into the fire. "I miss my wife," he said quietly into the silence.

Melog raised a questioning eyebrow, obviously inviting more information.

"Her name was Angella. She was Queen of Bright Moon. Glimmer's mother. Apparently, she was trapped in a collapsing portal dimension." Micah finished his glass. "I miss her."

The guardian edged forward until they could lay their head on Micah's feet.

"You know, Angella's parents opposed our marriage."

Melog lifted their head quizzically.

"When I was a kid, there was a… scandal." Micah shifts uneasily. "Someone… died. I wasn't responsible, but I felt… ." He stopped

and sighed. "I think everyone was actually pretty kind, but I… " He stopped again, grimacing. "It's hard when you are thirteen and you feel responsible for a death. Everyone told me it was not my fault. " After all this time, Micah almost believed them. "I just… I couldn't stay here, you know? And over the next few years, we lost more and more territory to the Horde. My parents wanted me to have some stability, a new start, I guess, so they sent me to Bright Moon. That's when I met Angie."

He stopped again, lost in his memories until Melog chittered questioningly.

"Angella became queen the year before we got married," Micah replied as though he understood. "Her parents wanted to retire. Angella is… was… a few years older than me. They were not all that keen on our relationship. It took a while before we were able to get their blessing. Not that it would have stopped us. I think Angie was ready to walk away from the Moonstone and the throne for me." A little sob erupted from his throat, and tears started down his cheeks.

Somehow, Melog became smaller and ended up with their whole self on Micah's lap, like a huge housecat.

"I miss her so much." Micah petted the creature as it purred. Melog was a good listener, and they had never heard any of Micah's stories. The long night passed slowly. Micah talked to Melog for a while about Angella and then fell silent. It was late, and he was tired. Physically he was comfortable, and the quiet companionship of this new friend he had made eased his heart.

In the warm silence, his eyes slipped shut. He dozed for a while in the cozy room, but pain roused him. An ache in his chest. It took a moment to realize the ache was more emotional than physical, the emptiness where his Angie should be, the pain of new grief.

The strange translucent cat still sat in his lap. It must have sensed him awaken because it opened its glowing blue eyes. The fire was low, and the room was almost completely dark. It was the

only source of *physical* illumination in the room. However, a column of energy emerged from Micah's chest, lighting the room with shifting patterns of magical light.

The magical tether was akin to the one that held his soul to his body. That made no sense; the essential part of *him* was still here, not wandering the astral plane. He had never seen a cord like this from the inside before. He looked more closely. Threads of black and white and violet pulsed and flowed, but thinner, weaker threads seemed to weave in and out of his energies. As he peered at it, he realized that a second cord, with threads of pink, white, and gold, wove into and wrapped around his, holding tight. It hurt- that was the pain that pulled him out of sleep.

The creature in his lap looked up at him, blinking slowly, then its gaze followed the cord, which extended a few feet, seeming to end abruptly in midair.

No, not in mid-air. Rather, it ended in a small glowing circle that looked like a hole in the universe. A tiny glowing tunnel about the width of his two fists led from nowhere to nowhere.

"What is that?" Micah breathed. If he were not a sorcerer, he would have assumed himself to be still sleeping, but part of a sorcerer's training was to be able to discern visions from mere dreams. To make absolutely sure, he drew the sigil for true sight. The glowing rope of magic and the bright white tear in reality remained.

Melog chirped and mewled. Micah had no idea what the thing wanted. It hopped off his lap and grew larger, tugging at his sleeve and looking toward the portal. It did this several times, then stared at Micah as though waiting for him to put something together,

"You want me to go through there?" he finally asked. "I won't fit."

Melog rolled their eyes and growled at him, but no helpful thoughts drifted through the sorcerer's head. The look the alien

gave him reminded Micah of how Light Spinner used to sit quietly while she waited for Micah to grasp a concept. She never told him any answers outright but always allowed him to puzzle out a task or concept for himself, giving him nudges in the right direction when necessary.

The sorcerer considered; it was not large enough to pass through physically, but perhaps Micah could send his awareness through there. If the opening closed when most of his awareness was on the other side, would it trap his soul? He knew nothing about these things. He assumed if that happened, his body would die in short order. There was no way to know if the portal would close because, as he understood it, portals needed a tremendous amount of energy to keep open.

"If I send myself out to take a look, will you keep the portal open?"

Melog nodded.

"If this goes wrong, will you find Castaspella?" It would probably be better to alert her now, but the spell or ritual or whatever the creature and he were doing seemed a private matter. Too intimate to involve anyone else.

Again a feline nod.

Micah settled in his chair and took deep breaths, beginning the process of dividing his soul from his body. It was a skill he often practiced on Beast Island to defend himself from the signal. It took but a second for him to stand up out of his corporeal self. When he looked back at it, the cat creature sat beside his inert-but-breathing body, no longer quite so catlike. Micah made a mental note to speak with Castaspella about it.

It gave him a little nod of acknowledgment, obviously able to see his spirit, and jerked its head as if to tell him to hurry up. Whatever the creature wanted Micah to see, it was at the other end of this tether.

Passing through the tunnel felt like falling into a bucket of white paint. The place seemed an endless void of white, and Micah was grateful that the cord he followed glowed steadily. It was indeed a kind of soul tether, and as he followed it, the threads of gold, white, and lilac began to outnumber the black, indigo, and violet.

Finally, in all the whiteness, a patch of green grass and shining gold. An exact replica of Bright Moon rose up out of the emptiness, except nothing living seemed to stir. Micah's shade followed the cord to the source.

Oh. Oh, of course.

The tether led to one of the pieces of his soul that he had given away. The one he thought he had lost forever.

Hair loose and blowing in the breeze, the Queen stood alone on the Moonstone's tower, her back turned to him, staring pensively into the city below, beautiful beyond anything Micah had ever seen.

Joyously, he called out, "Angella?"

The woman's wings went up, and she turned, her eyes wide, both stunned and glad. "Micah? What? How?" Then, she seemed to catch herself. She raised a hand to her brow, and her face sagged into sadness. "Ah, damn this place…." She shook her head. "Now, it has me seeing ghosts."

She turned away and then threw herself from the tower and flew off.

"Angie! Wait!" She paused in her flight. He thought she might have heard him, but at that moment, there was a pulling sensation and an almost physical feeling of snapping back to his body. Melog must have run out of the magical energy to keep the portal open.

"Does this mean there's still hope?" Micah whispered to the creature. He would have leaped up to find his sister, to ask her to

convene Mystacor's council, but he trembled with weariness, and his limbs were stiff.

Melog nodded and flopped down with a moan in front of the fire, their eyes closed.

Micah felt the same terrible dragging debility and knew nothing would happen until they rested. Both their strength and magic were spent for the moment. It was still dark. Quietly, without putting on any light beyond the fire so as not to disturb his guest, Micah undressed and got into his bed.

That she still existed had been quite a shock to Angella. When she had pulled the sword from the power source and flung it out of the Portal, she had not considered that she could survive in the rapidly collapsing pocket dimension. But what she thought was the onset of death had merely been unconsciousness. Sometime later, she had awoken on a white surface that was neither hard nor soft. There was air to breathe, but it carried no scent. The temperature was neither hot nor cold, and it never varied. The silence was deeper than anything she had ever experienced.

If the void had remained that way-- a void-- Angella would likely have gone mad in short order. At first, she flew through the endless white, fighting the vertigo of flying through nothing. When she was too spent to fly anymore, she walked until her strength gave out. Once she could no longer walk, she fell and wept until exhausted sleep overcame her.

Too weak from hunger and thirst to stand, she would have wept again when she woke up, but she had no tears left in her. In a way, that had been a relief. Although she did not age the way most Etherians did, she was still corporeal enough that starvation and dehydration would kill her (she hoped).

Lying on that surface (it was too white and formless to be called "ground"), her mouth and lips dry, her eyelids scratching every time she blinked. She closed her eyes, picturing the fountains and

waterfalls of Bright Moon. She had so many favorites. At that thought, she smiled at herself weakly. How could one have "so many" favorites? She considered further. The one in the grand ballroom was her favorite, she decided. She loved to hear the gentle burble in the background while she gazed at Micah's mural and imagined him watching over his family.

As she lay there waiting to die, she could imagine the sound as though it were right next to her. The floor under her seemed suddenly hard and cool, like the marble floors of Bright Moon. The imagined scent of water tormented her delirious mind. She seemed to be lying just on the fountain's edge as she used to do with her daughter on hot days.

It was bodily instinct that opened her dry eyes to see that her senses had conjured the illusion of a fountain. It was a simple animal reflex that caused her to cup the hallucinated liquid from the mirage into her hand and bring it to her lips.

A fierce physical relief gripped her as she swallowed, and the water tasted better than anything she had ever tasted. She plunged her head into the cold water. It took some time before her thirst was quenched, and she was able to look about herself and discover she *was* in Bright Moon.

No, not Bright Moon, but a magical replica that had to come from her own mind. For whatever reason, the rules of this tiny universe put her in control. Perhaps the Sword of Protection had done this-- created a world that catered to whoever controlled its magic? Since she had been the one to fling the artifact to Etheria's normal dimension, the sword's residual magic clung to her and mixed with her own. One of the first magical lessons any sorcerer learned is "like calls to like."

When the portal collapsed, and she was trapped, the magic responded to her unconscious body's call for air and gravity. For a stable "up" and "down," for light and space to move about in. When she collapsed from thirst and exhaustion, her body again demanded sustenance which took the form of what Angella

wanted most at that moment. Since then, she learned to tell the magic what she wanted without going to those extremes. She had in fact worked very diligently at shaping this magic. Having nothing else to do, she created the whole city of Brightmoon. And thus, she had become a goddess of creation, albeit for a minuscule world.

Angella flew on through the infinite void, considering Micah's appearance. She was losing her mind. The isolation was destroying her; she had known this for a while. Accepted it even. In the beginning, to ease her loneliness, she created magical constructs to talk to. That had palled quickly; when they spoke to her, she found it too eerie and strange, and she was all too aware that it was playacting. She sometimes still did it, even so.

Today was the first time she had seen a being that seemed not of her creation. She felt in her bones that Micah's voice was not from her mind. The thrum of Micah's magic against her wings was unmistakable. That was not even *possible* in this dimension. The voice only *felt* as though it were outside of herself. Some part of her mind had manufactured it. The only magic to exist here was *hers.*

There was, of course, the other problem: Micah was dead.

So there it was, at last. She was indeed going mad. It would be a change, at least.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Catra and Melog chat

Swiftwind returns

It felt strange to have so many clothes. Even when she was Hordak's Second, Catra never had this many. Some days it was so overwhelming she could almost understand why Adora clung to that old jacket. But Catra was determined to be adaptable. Aunt Casta and Glimmer had been taking great joy in helping them pick out new things that weren't just uniforms to wear. It felt strange and rebellious to wear soft fabrics that flowed around her after a lifetime of wearing clothes built for combat.

The downside to this abundance was laundry day. Mystacor, like Brightmoon, had a staff to take care of things like laundry and cleaning, but Catra always felt awkward about letting them into their room. Her compromise was to do what she used to do in the Horde. When the hamper was full, she dropped it into a laundry bag and left it in the hall for someone to pick up. The cleaning staff was allowed in once a week to change sheets and generally tidy. That was all the intrusion on her territory she could stand.

Catra's nose wrinkled as she dug into the laundry. She could smell blood. For once, it was not hers. She thought she remembered Adora coming in with a bloody nose the other day after sparring, but it did not seem enough to set off even her hypervigilant nose. She dropped the dirty clothes into the bag, but the blood smell did not diminish. She pulled out more clothing. At the bottom of the hamper, she found the source, a set of Adora's leggings, torn up, with a fair amount of blood at the knees. Typical Adora. She just could not stand to throw things out. These hardly looked worth saving, so Catra put them aside to throw out instead of being cleaned.

The ruined leggings worried her, but Catra could not understand why she felt that way. It just struck her as… wrong?. Catra could not remember Adora coming in with banged-up knees, but she probably transformed. Well, if it was important, she would figure it out.

The door swung open. Melog, their whole body washed out to a pallor almost as light as their mane, slunk in.

“Are you okay?” Catra asked, dismissing the laundry from her mind and jumping up to go over to her friend. She had never seen Melog look so drained.

“I am… tired,” the creature allowed. “I will sleep here for a while.” They staggered to the bed Cataspella had provided for them. “Later, I will go to the springs.” Melog loved the hot springs.

“Where were you last night?” Melog had tactfully disappeared when it became clear that Adora had planned an evening for her and Catra.

“I was with a friend,” they said vaguely. An image of Micah drifted through Catra’s head.

“What were you doing?” Catra didn’t think Melog ever indulged in alcohol or anything like that, but she would swear they seemed hung over.

“A magical experiment.”

“Did it not work?”

“Oh no, Granddaughter. It worked beyond my wildest hope.”

“Good? I guess?” If that was a success, Catra did not want to see failure.

“It was a beginning.” They collapsed onto their bed and fell asleep almost instantly.

Though the cavernous room was empty and the walls cracked and crooked, the halls of the ruin still echoed with a high-pitched chord that could have been the sound of a chorus of a hundred angelic beings. On the other hand, it could also have been the sound of a malfunctioning alarm. Adora's ears rang from her little stunt, so it was hard to tell.

Staggering, Adora caught herself on the wall, afraid that if she fell to the floor, she might not be able to get up again. Sweat or blood dripping from her brow burned her eyes, and every shining surface showed her battered reflection. Her cheeks were adorned with gritty bruises, her fists bloody and swollen, and a wound at her hairline, but it did not matter. Adora summoned her sword,

As She Ra, her wounds disappeared, and she stood reflected in the crystal in all her perfection. Gears ground within the place as it came to life. Even if the machinery was in ruins, the castle still recognized She Ra.

When Adora let the transformation go, the lights dimmed, and the distant humming of dilapidated machinery stopped. Her bones burning, she fell to her knees, curled in on herself. "Get the fuck up," she growled at her reflection. She needed to pull herself together and get back before Catra wondered where she was. She was not a great liar, and her wife would immediately call bullshit if she tried, so the best course was not to give Catra a reason to ask.

“Adora?” Someone called, their voice echoing through the ruin.

Swiftwind. Shit.

“I’m back here!” Adora planted her feet and used the wall to push herself up. By the time the horse found her, she stood almost normally, leaning against the wall for support.

“Hi, Adora!” he called as he got close.

“Hey, Swifty! What’s up?” The blonde tried to keep her tone light and casual.

“Oh, you know. Bringing the good news of freedom and revolution to the masses.” The horse struck a pose. “And the beautiful flowing hair.” He tossed his head dramatically. “Then I got this idea that you needed me here.” He tilted his head quizzically.

Grinning, Adora reached out to hug him. Something passed between them, and Adora’s aches lessened suddenly. “Well, I guess I was thinking about you,” she chirped, even though the realization that she had utterly forgotten how Swiftwind could get into her head horrified her. Even worse, she had no idea of the extent of it now that Etheria’s magic had been freed. “I haven’t seen you since…”

Swiftwind sighed, looking away. “Yeah. Sorry. I haven’t been around much.” On the day of the victory over Horde Prime, Swiftwind had taken it upon himself to spearhead the task of rounding up all of the domesticated horses, dogs, and cats that had been scattered and made homeless by the battles. “It’s been tough going,” he admitted. “There are so many refugees, and a lot of them are still hiding. They’re hungry, scared, and tired. Plus, a lot of them don’t want their lives just to be a return to bondage. I’ve been working with Hordak and Entrapta on a side project that uses machines rather than horses as draft animals for farming but its just difficult to convince folks who’ve been fighting the Horde their whole lives that their subjugation of my people is just as bad as living under Prime’s rule.”

“Yeah. There’s a lot of work to do,” Adora rested her hand on Swiftwind’s neck. “But I can’t think of a better horse for the job.”

He smiled at her praise, leaning his nose against her shoulder. “So, what are you doing here?” He asked, perking up.

“Oh. You know…” Adora thought fast. “Bow… His dads want to study the place, but it's a little dangerous right now. All the defenses are messed up. They won’t even listen to She Ra and….”

“Oh! Is that how you hurt yourself?” Swiftwind said, sounding relieved as though solving a minor mystery.

Adora stopped cold. “What? What do you mean?”

Swiftwind thought about it. “Yeah. Weird, huh? I just got this idea that you hurt yourself, and you needed me. You should have sent for me if you needed help.”

“Sorry, Swifty. I had no idea that you… “She stopped and started again. “I didn’t mean to take you away from whatever you were doing.”

“Eh, no worries. I get that it’s important to decommission this place properly.” The horse did a reasonable imitation of a human shrug. ”But, next time, let me know.”

Adora nodded quickly. “Sure, of course. I mean, I’m pretty much done for the day, and this is going to take a few weeks, and I kind of want to do it myself and….”

“Adora?” Swiftwind broke through her nervous ramble. “You okay?”

“What? Pfft. Of course, I’m okay. Why wouldn’t I be okay?”

“You don’t sound it.”

Stupid sacred bond. She sighed, trying to come up with something plausible.“It’s just… Catra and me…. “

Swiftwind’s ears went back, and he bared his teeth. “Is she treating you badly?” he growled. "I will absolutely kill her!" He took a step back as if he was going to go hunt Catra down right that second.

Taken aback, Adora shook her head hastily, putting out her hand to stop him. “No! No, nothing like that!” Swiftwind seldom got angry, but Adora knew that Swiftwind did not like Catra.

“Really?” he asked dubiously. “I’ve heard she’s not all that nice to her friends.” Swiftwind was close to both Entrapta and Scorpia.

“She’s been sick.” Adora finally said. She put her back against the wall and slid to the floor. “She… “ Suddenly, Adora did not have to plan what she was saying because a black pool of grief seemed to overflow into her chest. “Oh, fuck, Swifty! Prime… when she was chipped, he-he r-r-raped her." The story came out garbled by Adora's sobs, but Swiftwind seemed to get the gist, "and-and she got p-p-pregnant. She terminated it.“

He knelt on the floor so Adora could wrap her arms around him and cry into his neck. He nuzzled her shoulder with his nose until she was all cried out.

“Feel better now?” he asked gently after she had been quiet for a few minutes.

She wiped her swollen eyes. “Yeah. I’m sorry.”

“It’s okay. We’ve all been through a lot.” He paused, then said, “I’m sorry too.”

“What? Why are you sorry?” Adora asked, confused.

“I feel like I’ve let you down. I haven’t been there for you. You should feel like you can tell me anything. I’m your steed, after all.” He looked away as though ashamed. “Catra’s not my favorite person, but you chose her. I just shouldn't have assumed... Well, I guess I should be more supportive.”

“It’s okay. Just… just don’t mention to anyone what I told you?”

Swiftwind’s eyes were soft and understanding, “On my honor as your steed.” He seemed to cast around for a way to change the subject, then he said, “Scorpia told me you two are ‘Official’? What is that? Is that like married?”

Adora smiled sheepishly. “Yeah.”

Swiftwind goggled at her. “And you didn’t throw a party?”

“Huh?” Adora blinked, suddenly remembering the fact that in most of Etheria, they threw parties at any excuse, even something as personal and mundane as becoming an officially sanctioned couple. She knew that. She just never really applied it to herself. “Oh. That never occurred to me.”

The horse shook his head. “That’s it; I am going to talk to Bow and Glimmer. We are going to throw you both a huge wedding reception!” He nodded to himself importantly. “I bet we can get Glimmer to declare it an official holiday and everything!”

Unable to help it, Adora laughed at her steed's enthusiasm. “Let me run it by Catra,” she said. “She hates surprises, but she does like parties. I’m not sure how she’ll feel about being the center of attention for something like this, though.” She pushed herself to her feet, feeling lighter of heart than she had for days.

“Okay! You let me know!” Swiftwind scrambled up too. “Do you want a ride home?” he asked.

“No, I’m good. I have the skiff Scorpia gave us.” The horse looked disappointed, so Adora quickly went on. “If we’re going to convince people to use tech instead of draft animals, maybe She Ra should set an example. You’re my steed, but you’re my friend first.”

Swiftwind smiled. “Thanks, Adora.”

The strangers had come to Etheria as beggars in the wilderness, in need of succor. Fleeing from a war they were losing. Etheria and her chosen protector, She Ra, gave them shelter. The Protector provided her help and allowed them to mine the planet for its resources, believing them too weak to threaten her.

She was wrong.

The invaders betrayed the goddess’s avatar, the last She Ra that Etheria chose. The woman died in a fierce battle. In the moment of the mortal avatar’s passing, the First One’s sorcery stole the

goddess’s magic before She Ra could find a new host. They bound her in one of their runestones and created a false avatar, a She Ra they controlled.

But the woman’s heart had to be compatible with the Protector’s magic. When this false avatar discovered her master’s lies, she turned from them and hid the sword with its runestone deep in Etheria’s vast heartwood as she hid the planet in a shadow dimension. Mara died to protect Etheria and the universe. The goddess remained asleep, bound by the runestone.

Now, the sword had been broken, and Etheria’s magic freed. Now for the first time in a thousand years, the Protector herself had been awakened.

Late for dinner

Chapter Summary

Adora gets home late

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As she walked through the halls of Mystacor, Adora kept glancing at her reflection in the highly polished walls and windows, checking to make sure she was not limping. She may have overdone it a little, but it did not matter. Whatever she did to herself healed as soon as she transformed, leaving her skin whole and unmarked. Only the pain stayed. During the war, she found that It helped her focus when everything seemed strange and unreal.

Things felt strange and unreal today. She should have been back hours ago but lost track of time after Swiftwind left her. She did not want to mention to her wife that she had gone to the old temple. It would mean questions Adora did not want to answer, and Catra would worry. She would probably tell Glimmer and Bow, who would also worry.

Since Catra had been feeling better, Adora had been restless. Catra still did not feel up to leaving Mystacor yet. Still, she had been working from there in her capacity as ambassador for the Republic (as people currently called what was formerly Horde territory). Most days, she was at it all day, seeming to relish her role, happy to spend hours in meetings online with Scorpia, Entrapta, or Glimmer.

Adora wished she could be half as productive. She was not actually that good at planning during peacetime. To be honest, most of her plans, even during the war, had always relied on She Ra. And right now? No one really even wanted She Ra unless it was to go to some diplomatic meet-and-greet bullshit.

Today, she had been scheduled to inspect the rebuilding of the Salineas Sea Gate. She was not even needed to haul shit around. Scorpia had supplied heavy equipment, and all the workers Octavia brought with her were aquatics who could breathe underwater.

After ascertaining that neither Octavia nor Mermista needed She Ra, Adora went to the old temple to blow off steam, which sometimes took a while.

“Where have you been?” Catra demanded before Adora had even closed the door. “You promised to be back early. I’ve been waiting for you.” The magicat’s voice was sharp with annoyance. “You’re late.”

Adora’s innards turned to ice. Sometimes, Catra sounded so much like Shadow Weaver, especially when she was pissed off, that it made Adora’s stomach flip, and it seemed as though her former guardian stood in the room with them.

The Black Garnet’s red glow was the only illumination, and the sorceress’s spy things lurked in the corners of the room. The old woman loomed over the girl, her smooth tone belying the peril she represented. "Adora," the witch snapped in her mind. "You’re late. Where have you been?" Shadow Weaver tapped on the table menacingly with her talon-like fingernail. “I’ve been waiting.”

"I’m sorry." *Adora began quickly, unsure what the sorceress wanted to hear and wondering for the millionth time why she was so stupid. She knew her mentor was disappointed, and it was dangerous to disappoint Shadow Weaver. In terror, the child stuttered,* “I-I lost track of time.”

Adora clenched her fists to still the shaking of her hands, and the deep burn of her speed-healed fractures brought her back to reality. They were not in Shadow Weaver’s study. Shadow Weaver was dead, and no shadows lurked where they shouldn’t.

Catra stared, her head tilted, her eyes narrowing. "You? Lost track of time?"

Okay, that did sound like a bullshit excuse. Punctuality was one of those things Adora had always prided herself on.

"I expect that sort of excuse from Catra, not from you." Shadow Weaver's hand stroked Adora's face, making her skin crawl.

"I'm sorry. I'll do better." Just like always, Adora's words tumbled over themselves as she tried to articulate her skittering thoughts. "Well, Mermista didn't have anyone who could move some rocks, and then… I saw Swifty, and you know how he is... He wanted to talk about some stuff. And then Glimmer needed something and…" she trailed off. Shit. Why did she bring up Glimmer? Catra talked to Glimmer almost every day. This is why she was so bad at lying. Her head hurt, and a dull nausea had settled into her gut.

"Seriously?" The magicat's tail lashed, and her ears went back. "Whatever. It's fine. It's not like you knew I was waiting for you or anything." Her lips curled into a familiar sneer, and she crossed her arms over her chest. "It's not like I was wondering if you were ever coming back," she muttered.

"Of course, I was coming back." Adora blurted, her voice too loud, but she was surprised. Did Catra still not trust her? After all, they'd been through?

Well, what did you expect? She's never understood you. Shadow Weaver said snidely in Adora's head. *You know how selfish she is.*

Yes. Selfish. Catra never understood Adora's responsibilities. Never understood how much Adora fought for her. How much bullshit Adora had to go through because Catra could never keep a respectful tongue in her head.

"She's your responsibility. You should have more control over your underlings if you ever expect to be a force captain.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver. I'll make her listen. I can fix this."

The witch brushed Adora's hair out of her eyes. "That's right. Now, come and show me how grateful you are for giving her another chance."

Acid bubbled up in the back of Adora's throat. "How could you even think that? Don't you trust me?"

"How could I think that?" Catra laughed bitterly. "Oh, that's funny coming from you," she growled. Before she could say anything else, Melog butted against Catra's legs. "What?!" she turned and snarled into Melog's face.

The great creature chirped and trilled, their ears back and their mane jagged. Whatever they were saying, Catra did not like it, and she hissed at them. They hissed right back, then chittered and growled.

"I am not!" Catra asserted her tail lashing.

Melog sat down on their haunches and stared at her, their eyes blinking slowly.

Catra turned her back on both of them with a snarl, her shoulders shaking as though she was crying. Adora went to step forward, but Melog gently put their mouth around her wrist to stop her. When Adora looked at them, they shook their head. Melog did that a lot.

For a few interminable minutes, Catra stood with her head hanging, hugging herself. Finally, she blew out a long breath and raked her hands through her short hair, and her ears relaxed from where they were pinned against her skull.

"Yeah, yeah. Okay." She turned to face Melog again. "I know," she whispered to the alien cat, "I know." She scrubbed at her swollen eyes before she buried her face in their mane. Melog purred, turning to lick Catra's face as the magicat leaned on them, seeming to draw strength from the contact. "I'll try." After a second, she straightened up, braced herself visibly, and then met Adora's eyes.

“I’m sorry. I shouldn’t’ve yelled.” Catra shrugged jerkily; her tail held straight out and fluffy behind her. Adora always thought of it as her nervous tail.

Catra took another deep breath and cleared her throat, holding herself with one arm across her stomach, grasping the opposite elbow. “Umm… When-when you were late, I got freaked out.” She bit out as if every word hurt. “Because you’re never late. And… “ Her voice shook a little. “It… um… I feel like…” Catra glanced at Melog, and the great creature nodded gently. "I-I'm worried you're mad at me," Catra said in a rush. She made a little noise that could have been a sniffle and hunched in on herself, apparently unable to hold the eye contact. After a moment, she started again, her voice soft and vulnerable. "You’ve been coming in late all week.” That was true. Catra had been asleep every night when Adora stumbled home. “And... and you didn’t call. You didn’t pick up when I called, either. I didn’t know where you were.” She hesitated and looked at her toes rather than at Adora. “And I got scared.”

Adora blinked, her heart twisting at the admission. Catra was trying *so* hard.

Hesitantly, making sure to telegraph every movement so as not to startle her, Adora moved into her space, gently putting a hand on her shoulder. Much to Adora’s relief, Catra met her halfway and stepped into her arms, tucking her head under Adora’s chin. The blonde could feel the magicat shaking. “Scared?” Adora asked gently.

“That, that something happened to you,” Catra said in an embarrassed whisper. “I-I-I know it’s stupid. And it wasn’t even just that. I haven’t seen you for weeks. I know we’re both busy, but I wanted to see you tonight. I-I got scared you’re tired of me. And I got mad because I was scared." She swallowed loudly. “I’m sorry.”

Burying her nose in Catra’s short, thick hair, Adora breathed in deeply. Catra smelled like the mineral salts in the hot springs.

Had she gone there? That did not seem likely, but Melog liked them, so maybe? But maybe not; If she had gone to the hot springs, wouldn't the salt make her fur and hair feel rough? The magicat's hair and fur were softer than Adora could ever remember. Thinking about the silky feel and scent helped distract Adora from the Shadow Weaver voice in her head.

"Shh. It's okay. I'm sorry." Adora backed off and looked down at the shorter woman. "It… I guess that's one of the things that's changed about me. I'm not used to someone caring about whether I'm late." That was not a lie. After Angella's death, when Glimmer became so overbearing, Adora began slinking into meetings at the last minute, especially near the end when Glimmer started consulting with Shadow Weaver.

"Why didn't you pick up?" Catra's voice was plaintive.

"I… Um… Well, I spent most of the afternoon as She Ra." Adora usually carried her communicator in her ear these days, but if she forgot to take it off, it disappeared into whatever magical realm her clothes went into when she transformed.

"Oh."

"Did you eat already?" Adora asked.

Catra sniffed, shook her head, and whispered, "I just wanted to wait for you."

"I'm sorry." No wonder Catra had yelled at Adora. She had been hungry as well as anxious. "Well, I'm here now. And I am hungry. They're still serving in the dining hall. Or would you rather we ordered something brought up?"

Melog made a little sound in their throat, and Catra nodded at whatever they said. Her shoulders dropped, and her ears came forward as a sweet smile bloomed on her face. "We could go down… And after, maybe take a walk on the beach? It's getting dark. I kind of thought we could go look at the stars." She finished shyly.

Adora nodded, feeling the tight knot in her stomach begin to relax. "Yeah, that would be nice." She bent to touch her lips to Catra's. They were soft and gentle, and for some reason, Adora felt surprised. The lips she kissed should be thinner, more demanding. The soft-furred cheek she stroked should be ridged with scars. The hand that drifted down to her hip was going to shove itself down her clothes and…

There, my dear, you see how good girls get rewarded?

Adora broke off with a gasp and pushed Catra back quickly. A confused crease appeared on Catra's brow, but Adora huffed a nervous chuckle before the other woman could get the wrong idea. "We'll never get dinner if you start that."

The magicat's face cleared, and she giggled, a squeaky little sound that Adora loved almost as much as she loved Catra's purr. "Yeah. Okay."

"So, how's the rebuilding going?" Catra asked as they walked down to the dining hall.

"It's going well," Adora said, hoping to avoid the details. "We're making a lot of progress." At least, from Adora's fifteen or twenty-minute tour of the Seagate project, she thought they were.

"That's great," Catra said. "I'm glad you're able to help."

Adora smiled, glad that Catra did not seem to suspect anything. "Thanks."

They talked about trivial stuff over dinner. Holding Catra's hand and sitting so close to her on the bench that their sides touched felt lovely. Adora suddenly realized it had been weeks since they had just sat and talked like this. As they were leaving, Adora stopped and turned to Catra.

"I'm really sorry I haven't been around much lately," she said. "I promise I'll make it up to you."

Catra smiled, but it had a worried edge to it. "It's okay," she said. "I know we're both busy. I'm just glad you're here now."

Adora smiled back. "Me too," she said as they headed down the passage to the beach.

The stars were no less beautiful than they had been the first time Adora saw them, and walking on the beach hand in hand with her wife should have been perfect, but she still felt rattled by the memory of Shadow Weaver earlier. The sorceress's voice was still so clear in her mind.

Adora would never tell Catra how much like Shadow Weaver she was. It was useless to hope that they would ever forget about the old witch, but she hoped that one day she would be able to think about her without feeling… Adora could not even name what she felt. There was fear and anger, but there was also grief, and what Shadow Weaver had said was love.

A frown line appeared between Catra's eyebrows. "I just asked where you've been. Are you okay?"

Adora shook her head, trying to clear it. "I'm fine," she said. "I just... got lost in thought."

"About what?" Catra asked.

Adora hesitated, embarrassed by how much space the old woman was taking up in her head. "It's nothing," she said finally.

"Nothing?" Catra's tail lashed, and Adora scrambled to think of something to appease her.

"It's just… " Her conversation with Swiftwind came back to her. "I was thinking that I needed to go back and make sure the Crystal Castle is properly decommissioned. I don't want anyone to get in there and get hurt." Adora could not lie well, but she had learned how to be circumspect with the truth she told.

You don't have to tell the others, my dear. This is our secret.

Chapter End Notes

Happy I'm finally able to update!

August was a bit of a nightmare. I had two heart attacks, and I am still recovering. So this is yet more stress writing.

Entanglements

Chapter Summary

> Adora has been spending a lot of time helping with various rebuilding projects. Yesterday morning, she took their skiff to Salineas. Catra has dinner and late-night talks with friends.

Chapter Notes

> Chapter Beta'd by Døc

Since Catra returned to work, Adora had been spending a lot of time helping with various rebuilding projects. Yesterday morning, she took their skiff to Salineas. Last night, she texted to say that Mermista had offered to let her stay the next day or two.

As grateful as she was that Adora remembered to call and let her know what was going on, Catra caught herself tapping her claw against the table, a frown knitting her brows. She took a deep breath and consciously relaxed her shoulders. They did not need to be joined at the hip. Salineas was a long ride on a skiff. Staying there for a few days to do whatever Mermista needed made sense.

It just left Catra feeling at loose ends. She had been working all day but now that she had signed off her terminal, she felt both bored and restless.

"You could visit the Sorceress," Melog suggested mildly.

"Oh, she's probably too busy, " Catra began, feeling awkward about just randomly knocking on the woman's door. She would obviously be too busy to hang out with Catra.

"She enjoys your company." Melog's quiet matter-of-factness cut through Catra's spiral, and her automatic spike of irritation at being told what to do was drowned out by the realization that she felt lonely.

"Fiiiine," Catra grumped, tilting her ears back, knowing that Melog understood that her resistance was only to save face.

Stretching, Catra stood up from her desk, closing the report she was reading. Melog paced alongside her to Aunt Casta's door. Raising her hand, Catra hesitated, wondering if the woman was even here. She glanced at Melog, who trilled encouragement.

"One moment!" called the sorceress at Catra's knock.

Light footsteps and the door opened, revealing Aunt Casta, bare-headed and bare-armed, wearing only a sleeveless shift.

"Hi." Awkwardly, Catra rested her hand on Melog's shoulder, ruffling their weird not-fur. This was the first time she had approached Castaspella rather than the other way. It felt both risky and vulnerable. She hoped the woman did not mind being disturbed when she was relaxing.

"Catra!" Aunt Casta exclaimed after an initial moment of surprise. Her brow furrowed."Are you all right, dear?"

"Yeah." Catra's cheeks heated up, and she wondered why she thought this was a good idea. "I, um, I wondered if you wanted to have dinner together?" She shifted from foot to foot. "I mean, if you weren't doing anything else?"

Castaspella's face lit up with a delighted smile. "I would love that! Shall we walk down together?"

"I'd like that."Catra's shoulders dropped with relief. Melog nosed into Aunt Casta's hand and looked at Catra almost smugly.

"Why don't you come in? I just need to change. I'll only be a minute." The sorceress disappeared into the other room, allowing Catra to look around the space.

Catra had never been inside Castaspella's personal apartment before, only her office. It was much larger than Catra and Adora's room next door and far less minimalistic than her office, with a

huge bookshelf dominating the small sitting room. A couch and several comfortable chairs by her fireplace looked like a cozy spot to sit and converse. Small throw blankets covered the backs of each chair, and beside the one closest to the fire was one of the sorceress's ever-present knitting projects.

"Where is Adora tonight?" the sorceress asked as she returned from the bedroom, securing her long robe and donning the circlet she wore whenever she left her rooms.

"Salineas. She said she'd be back tomorrow." Catra shrugged. "I wasn't really in the mood to go."

Aunt Casta nodded. It was no secret that the relationship between Mermista and Catra, though cordial, was still tentative.

As they walked down toward the dining hall, Aunt Casta linked her arm with Catra's. The young woman stiffened for a moment. She was not yet accustomed to so much casual contact, but the sorceress's grasp was loose enough that Catra did not feel the immediate urge to pull away.

"So nice to see you looking better," Aunt Casta said approvingly, then she made a little noise in her throat. "But you're still so thin. Have you been eating?"

"Yes. I have," Catra muttered, feeling her cheeks heat, unsure what to do with the woman's concern. It felt odd to have anyone care.

"I know you're been working a lot. Are you sleeping?"

"Yes."

Melog made a noise, and Aunt Casta raised an eyebrow.

Catra rolled her eyes. "I'm sleeping better than I was," she said, feeling a little like they were ganging up on her.

Apparently, Aunt Casta heard the defensiveness because she immediately backed off. “I’m sorry. I don’t mean to be intrusive.” She did seem contrite. “Don’t mind me. I’m afraid I am a bit of a worrier.” Her face softened, and she squeezed Catra’s arm. “I always worry about the people I care about.”

“It’s okay,” Catra mumbled as she rubbed the back of her neck with her free hand, wondering why her throat felt thick and her eyes prickled.

“Glimmer always warned her friends I was ‘a lot’.” The older woman smiled wryly as she leaned in conspiratorially. “You should ask her about it. I drove her mad when she was younger. She’ll tell you all kinds of terrible stories about me, I’m sure.” She chuckled self-deprecatingly.

It was late, and the large dining hall was closed. Most students and teachers ate early since most had morning classes. An informal late supper was served in the small dining room for the denizens of Mystacor that kept later hours. The late supper was purposely casual so that folks who did not want to eat in their rooms or apartments could enjoy a meal without worrying about standing on ceremony. As such, the food was laid out on a buffet, and people just helped themselves rather than waiting to be served. It was strangely comforting to Catra, as it reminded her of the Horde dining halls (only the food was so much better).

A few people Catra did not know sat around the half-dozen circular tables either alone or in twos or threes. A few of them smiled and nodded at Castaspella in greeting as she and Catra picked out something to eat.

They settled down at the table and chatted over their meal, with the sorceress asking about Catra’s work and how the rebuilding of the Horde Republic was going.

After the meal, they lingered, talking over a glass of wine until it became apparent that the kitchen staff was ready to close for the night.

The night was quiet around them, and the lights in the corridors had dimmed.“Can I ask you a question?” Aunt Casta hesitantly asked as they walked back up to their rooms.

Trying not to get her hackles up at the woman’s tone, Catra grunted, “I guess.” Mentally she braced herself for a personal question, reminding herself that Castaspella had never once crossed a line Catra set.

“So, I’ve heard that Micah and Melog have been working together on a magical experiment?”

That was not what Catra expected. “Yes. They have.”

“Do you know what it is about?”

“Did he not tell you?” countered Catra quietly, unsure if she should say too much. She would have thought that Aunt Casta was the first person he’d tell. Catra understood why he wouldn’t want to say anything to Glimmer. It was the same reason Catra did not want to tell her; neither of them wanted to raise false hopes in the young queen.

“Well, no. I haven’t seen him lately. I’m not sure, but I feel like he may be avoiding me.” The normally sedate woman was beginning to wring her hands. She sighed heavily. “I’m sorry, Catra. I don’t mean to put you in a difficult spot,” she said softly, wrapping her arms around herself as if she was cold. “I certainly don’t want you or Melog to betray anyone’s confidence, but I don’t want Micah to get hurt. If you can’t tell me, that’s fine.”

Biting her lip, Catra glanced at Melog, who serenely padded beside Catra, unbothered by Aunt Casta’s questioning.

“You may tell her that the Sorcerer will be in no danger,” Melog chirruped thoughtfully. “I think his secrecy is merely habit. They protected each other when they were children, and now they seek to provide protection where none is needed.” The magical cat considered. “The Sorcerer never gave me any reason to think he

would not want the Sorceress to know. I have no reason not to discuss at least our part in it."

"What about…?" Catra asked, trailing off and hoping Melog would understand what she was asking.

"I do not think the news about the Queen's Mother would be harmful here. The Sorceress may even prove to be a resource."

Catra nodded, accepting Melog's word for it. "It's not anything that Micah will get hurt doing," she said. "Melog has been… " she hesitated, unsure how to phrase it. "They've been looking for Queen Angella."

Aunt Casta stopped walking, her dark eyes snapping to Catra's face. "Melog found evidence that Angella is still alive?" Aunt Casta's voice was low, as though she did not want any passersby to hear, although no one was in the corridor with them.

Evidence. That was one way to put it. Catra nervously cleared her throat. She did not want to promise anything she could not deliver. Not about this. "We think… At least- Entrapta's pretty sure… we can open a stable portal to get her back again. We're not sure how long it will take, but…

"But Angella is definitely alive?" Aunt Casta breathed. "You're sure?" Her expression was unreadable.

"The old queen lives. I am certain," Melog told Catra helpfully. "I cannot find those who have departed for the sunless lands."

"Melog is sure." Catra left out the part about 'sunless lands'. Sometimes, Melog had a way of making things sound creepier than they needed to.

Castaspella made a noise like a sob and covered her face with her hands.

Awkwardly, Catra shifted on her feet, glancing at Melog, silently begging her friend to tell her what to do. They cocked their head

and nodded towards the distressed woman like Catra should know. That was no help.

Out of her depth and remembering what Arrow Boy always did when someone got upset, Catra tentatively put her hand on the other woman's shoulder.

Aunt Casta covered Catra's hand with her own. "I'm sorry," Castaspella took a deep breath and wiped her face with her free hand. "I never… " The words were thick, and she trailed off, shivering where she stood.

Catra glanced around, relieved that they were alone. She was certain that the dignified ruler of Mystacor did not want to be seen sobbing in the middle of the hallway. She led the distraught woman to sit on one of the cushioned benches that lined the wall.

"Do you want to talk about it?" Catra asked quietly. "It's okay if you don't," she added quickly. "I get that it might be weird. We can talk about something else."

Clearing her throat, the woman tried again. "Angella and I never truly got along," she confessed. "And… I'm afraid I always blamed her for… " Her voice ended with a squeak, and she took a long breath, wiping her eyes. She lifted her head and gave Catra a watery smile. "Don't say anything more, my dear. I will go ask Micah." She turned her head to look at Melog. "Please look after my brother," she told the magical creature. "I'm afraid his life on Beast Island may have left him likely to take foolish risks."

Melog leaned into her hand, communicating their response clearly enough that Catra did not need to translate.

"Come along, now." Aunt Casta stood so calmly after her outburst that Catra found it a little unnerving. "Would you like to come work on your knitting with me for a while?"

Catra nodded eagerly, happy to step back from that alarming topic. When they reached their rooms, the young woman ducked

inside her bedroom, grabbed the scarf she had been working on, and returned to sit down in front of Aunt Casta's fire.

For some time, they sat together, knitting quietly.

"You know, I took up knitting because I could never sit still in my classes," Castaspella confided.

"Really?" Catra lifted her gaze from her handwork. Castaspella almost never seemed anything less than perfectly serene.

"Hmm. I was a high-strung child, and I discovered it helped soothe my anxiety." She smiled lightly. "Everyone is accustomed to my knitting my way through council meetings now."

That was understandable. Everything about knitting soothed Catra. The yarn sliding through her fingers and across her claws felt to her fingers the way Melog's purrs sounded to her ears. The repetition of needle-through-loop, wrap-yarn, needle-through-loop, and slip-yarn kept her restless hands happy while her thoughts went quiet and detached. She found it easier to contemplate problems when her hands and eyes were otherwise engaged.

The scarf Catra had started a few days ago was almost finished; she'd have to ask Aunt Casta how to get it off the knitting needles so the fabric didn't unravel. Distantly, she wondered if sorcery was involved.

Melog yawned.

"Is that a hint?" Aunt Casta asked, grinning. "I think Melog is ready for bed."

Both women laughed when Melog made a little yip of assent.

The light above Adora's head glittered and refracted. The little rainbows would be beautiful if their spinning did not make her nauseous. Her legs hurt. She had tried to stand, but they had

wobbled and collapsed. Not at her knees, but at the unnatural angle of her thigh bones. She lay on her back and stared up at the crystal ceiling.

Had Horde soldiers felt like this as they lay in their burning tanks? They would have felt much worse, Adora was sure. For Adora, it was merely pain. For the injured Horde soldier, assuming they lived, their fear and pain would last for months and months. Many times, that pain would never fully heal.

"Soon, we'll be calling the shots," Catra had said at Thaymore. Before that, when they were children, Adora told Catra all her heroic fantasies. She was sure that when she and Shadow Weaver ran the Horde, Adora would make sure everyone had enough to eat. She would invent armor to keep soldiers from getting killed. The Horde would make all of Etheria safe and orderly. She would help their people.

"You left us for them? Ugh, what happened to you?"

What made Adora turn away from her own people without a second thought? Some kind words and a plate of food? What made Adora choose THAT moment to grow a conscience? She saw what Shadow Weaver did to people. It was not just Catra. Everyone knew not to cross the old woman. But Adora had always justified it to herself, telling herself that Shadow Weaver had to be strict to enforce discipline. That the blatant favoritism was somehow deserved.

At the time, Adora thought Catra's face showed only anger and betrayal, but now? She recognized Catra's fear now. And she was right to be afraid, wasn't she? What had happened to Adora in those few hours, less than a day, that would shake the foundations of her very soul?

The Sword had happened. Tripping the switch in Adora's brain that Light Hope had planted there. It was as much mind control as Prime's chips, Adora realized, only slower and more insidious. Although, when she considered it, when Prime was stealth-

chipping Etherians, they retained enough of their own identity to believe they were making choices of their own free will.

Of course, Adora never had much free will, did she? Catra said she was a people pleaser, and she was not wrong. Razz had said it. "You ask the first old lady you meet what you should do." Sometimes, Adora thought the first decision she had ever made with any modicum of free will had been when she broke the sword. Before that, her entire life had been about doing what she was told.

That day in Thaymore, in the smoke of battle, Catra had declared where her loyalties would lie. Catra had nearly conquered all the Alliance nations and would no doubt have continued to expand beyond.

For a moment, Adora imagined what that would have looked like. Her breath came in short gasps, and the dark pushed into her mind. If she waited too long, no doubt Swiftwind would show up the way he had the other day. Before that happened, she reached out her hand and called up the sword. The magic was slow, but the sword appeared. Today, when she spoke the words, they came in a thick croak.

The magic burned away her pain. Her broken bones straightened. The blood and grime that clung to her evaporated into the ether. She stood.

"What are you doing, Adora?" a voice murmured behind her.

The blonde giantess whipped around in surprise. Mara, in her She Ra form, stood in the corridor. Only Mara's form was different. Her eyes and hair were dark instead of fair, and her armor was battle-scarred.

Instead of saying anything, Adora stood and walked away. She would not argue with a hologram, and it did not matter what it witnessed or what she said to it. She Ra probably looked different

because the computer that created the holograms could not decide if it wanted to show her She Ra or Mara.

“You are hurting yourself,” Mara said implacably.

“Yeah, well, that’s not really new, is it?” Adora muttered.

Mara stepped forward, her presence both imposing and comforting. "The path of a hero is never easy, Adora. It's filled with doubts, fears, and sometimes, the feeling of being utterly lost."

Those were definitely the words of a malfunctioning computer. It merely echoed Light Hope.

"But remember, you're not defined by the sword or by the battles you've fought. You're defined by your heart, your will to do what's right, even when it's the hardest choice to make."

Adora rolled her eyes. The only one who was better at dishing out this sort of manipulative nonsense was Shadow Weaver. The old woman had seen to it that Adora would happily shoot in whatever direction she was pointed. A shudder passed through the young woman, and cold fury erupted in her stomach. "But what if I don’t want to make those choices anymore?" she snarled. Now, she faced Mara merely as herself. However, with She Ra absent, the room was nothing more than a dark cave, and Adora was alone.

Most of the residents of Mystacor had already taken to their beds, so Catra wound up her knitting, and she and Melog headed back to their room.

Catra’s tracker pad buzzed with a text from Adora.

Sorry. It got super late while I was talking with Mermista. Just wanted to say good night. A little heart followed the text.

Shaking her head at her sappy girlfriend, Catra texted back, *Love you too. Go to bed.*

Soft footsteps walked past their door. Catra didn't pay much attention to them. Even though the war was over, at least one or two sorcerers were always on duty to patrol the corridors. She suspected that they lurked on this floor more often than the others. The implication didn't bother her--in fact, she sincerely *hoped* they retained enough caution to keep an extra eye on Castaspella since a former enemy had moved into the guest room.

Tonight, that patrol seemed determined to be thorough. The footsteps stopped outside the door and then started again. Fading as though they were walking away, then came back. Faded again and came back. They seemed to stop right at the door. Someone sighed almost inaudibly, and then a scraping sound as if they leaned their back against it and slid down until they sat on the floor.

That was new.

Melog lifted their head and cocked one eyebrow quizzically at Catra. She nodded at them and quietly got off the bed, leaving her knitting behind. She unsheathed her claws, just to be safe, and opened the door with a quick yank.

The body huddled against their door jumped up and away, turning around to face her. A faint lavender ball floated by the person's shoulder, giving out just enough light that the average human wouldn't trip over furniture in the dark, which meant to Catra's eyes it was almost daylight. Much to her surprise, Glimmer stood in the hallway in her sleeping clothes and a blanket wrapped around her shoulders. A pillow that usually lined one of the stone window seats lay on the floor.

"Catra!" Glimmer whispered, her face awash with tears. "I'm sorry! I didn't mean to wake you." She glanced at the door of her aunt's room.

“Hey, it’s okay. I wasn’t asleep. What’s up?” Catra stepped towards her, wondering if she should call Adora. Given how badly her wife had been sleeping for the past week, she didn't want to, but she also knew that Adora would want a call if something were wrong.

“N-nothing…I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to disturb you guys. This was a mistake. I’ll just…”

Before Glimmer could disappear, Catra’s hand shot out and grabbed the other woman’s wrist in a firm, clawless grip. “No, it’s okay. Just come in.”

The Queen of Brightmoon shook her head. “No. It’s stupid. It can wait until morning.” She looked away. “Don’t wake Adora. I know she hasn’t been sleeping.”

Without letting go of her wrist, Catra stared at her, trying to determine what was happening. “Where’s Bow?” she asked, finally.

Glimmer smiled, but the expression was strained. “Oh, he went to visit his dads.” She gave a jerky little shrug. “It’s fine.” Her hand in Catra’s grip was cold, and she pulled it back, ready to turn away. Glimmer was not nearly as bad a liar as Adora, but it was pretty clear she was not fine.

“Hey. Wait.” Catra let go of Glimmer’s wrist and instead wrapped her hand around the other woman’s icy fingers. She was not sure what to say, but she was confident that it would be a terrible idea to let Glimmer leave, so she said the first thing that came to mind. “You know what, I’m hungry. How about we raid the kitchen?” She smirked conspiratorially. “I know for a fact there is some cake down there. We can eat right off the platter if you want.”

Glimmer’s smile reached her eyes. “Okay.”

A blink and they were in the kitchen. As usual, Catra’s stomach rebelled from the teleport. “Will you NOT do that,” she snapped, as she gripped at a door frame.

“Sorry,” Glimmer replied in a small voice. “I forgot.”

After a second, the nausea passed. “S’okay.” Catra ran her hand through her hair and shook her head. “Come on, let’s get something to eat.”

Doubts and Shadows

Chapter Summary

Glimmer and Catra eat cake. Adora tries to clear her head.

Chapter Notes

Thanks to Døc for the Beta-ing

Rifling through the pantry, Glimmer found the cake and cut two big slices while Catra got glasses and milk from the cold storage. They both sat down, grinning at each other over their plates before they started.

"So, did Adora have a good time at the Horde Capital yesterday?" Glimmer asked with her mouth full.

Catra, reaching for the milk, made a sharp movement, and the empty glass slipped from her hand. "Fuck," she swore, grabbing it before it shattered on the tile.

"You okay?"

Catra growled to herself, but out loud, she said. "Yeah, it's fine. It's just late." Something cold and uneasy settled into her gut. "Weird. She told me she was helping Mermista near the Sea Gate."

The air between them thickened with confusion and concern. "But that doesn't make any sense." Glimmer's eyebrows furrowed as she processed Catra's words. "What did she say when she got home tonight?"

Catra's tail flicked in agitation. Had Adora finally learned how to lie? "She isn't here." Of course, this being Adora, she would not learn to lie well. The dark-haired woman leaned on the table, crossing her arms defensively. She felt sick, worse than when Glimmer teleported them. "She said she was staying with

Mermista tonight." A thousand scenarios flashed through her mind.

Glimmer paused, her face softening. Then, she reached across the table, covering Catra's hand with her own. "Catra, it's probably nothing to worry about. Adora gets mixed up sometimes, you know?" She smiled, trying to lighten the mood. "Actually, now that I think about it, she told me she was staying in Salineas next week, not this one. She does that, you know? She can never keep her calendar straight. Always mixing up dates."

"She… does?" Catra blinked. She did *not* know that. It was always weird when she encountered something like this—some small detail that had changed or perhaps just revealed itself in their time apart.

"Oh yeah. When she first got here, it was like she never had to be on time for anything in her life before. We just used to haul her around whenever we had to be somewhere."

That… would explain some things," Catra said. When Adora was late for dinner last week, she had basically said the same thing: that she often lost track of time. It had felt like a lame excuse. Catra always thought of Adora as punctual. The better student, the better athlete, the better everything—the one who was intrinsically *good* at anything she tried.

But, now, what Glimmer was saying made Catra really *think* about it. Shadow Weaver would throw a fit if Adora got anything less than near-perfect marks. Everyone would suffer if that happened, and so they all pitched in. Catra double-checked her math homework. Lonnie made sure Adora was up to snuff for every combat training. Kyle and Rogelio ensured she completed her history and language homework on time. Adora was naturally an early riser, true, but she never had a *chance* to screw up.

Once, it might have given Catra a little thrill of triumph that she was better than Adora at something. Now, however, it just felt disorienting.

Melog appeared in the kitchen, butting their head into hand and reeling in Catra's insecurities. "Grandaughter, You know your mate is faithful." They did not say anything else, but Catra had the distinct impression that Melog would definitely know if Adora was not.

Glimmer shrugged. "I'll take you there in the morning if you want. I don't have any meetings that can't wait.

"I'm not worried," Catra muttered, her cheeks heating up.

Okay." Glimmer nodded, then, as if sensing Catra wanted to drop it, said, "Speaking of mix-ups, Bow got super weird a few weeks ago. You know how he's so bad at lying? So I was kind of freaking out, but then it turned out he was making this for me." Glimmer held up a small golden heart on a chain. "He was planning the perfect moment to give it to me."

"You're Official? That's great!" Catra grinned. "But why was he being weird about it?"

"Oh, well, not yet. We're not. There's a whole big ceremony. It's kind of a big deal, so he asked me last night and gave me this." She gestured at the pendant. "That's where he's gone tonight. To tell his dads and get some advice for the wedding." Her smile turned mischievous. "I get the idea that Bow knew his dads were going to get way too embarrassing when he told them."

Catra returned the smile.

"You two should have a reception, though. You're both public figures," Glimmer said, cocking her head. "People really expect it."

"Yeah. Adora said something about that. Like we're supposed to throw some sort of party?" Catra pushed the niggling doubts to the back of her head, determined not to spiral over something as insignificant as her idiot wife mixing up the dates in her calendar.

Adora curled up on the cracked floor of the temple. The darkness gnawed at the edges of her mind, but she could not stop the thoughts that bounced around in her skull. She focused on her breathing. Perfuma said it would help. Of course, Perfuma said many things about what Adora should be doing for her mental health. None of it seemed helpful right now.

That's not fair; a little voice in the back of Adora's head chided her. Perfuma only said those things because she worried about her friends. The Flower Princess had given her countless tips on managing stress and anxiety—breathing exercises, mindfulness, and positive affirmations. Adora knew these were meant to help, but in moments like this, they felt woefully inadequate. Anyway, other people need her more; others, like all the Horde soldiers She Ra maimed during the war.

It was late. Adora had texted Catra an hour ago that she was going to bed, but the blonde could not close her eyes. She was so tired. She always needed sleep after speed healing, which was usually fine. She would just pass out cold the minute she stopped being She Ra. Tonight, though, she could not. It was a terrible idea to sleep here anyway, but there was no way she could go home in this state. She would have to transform to stay awake long enough to pilot her skiff, and Catra might catch on that her sleep was not natural. Bow told her he could tell when she was sleeping off a speed healing, and if Bow could tell, Catra definitely could.

She lay on her side, pulling her knees to her chest, tucking her jacket under her head, and wishing she had brought a blanket. The floor was cold, and it seemed to sink into her bones.

Clearly, sleep was not on the table right now.

Frustration boiled over into a low growl, her voice echoing in the empty chamber. She stood, cursing herself for being soft. Her chest felt tight, as if someone was sucking the atmosphere from the room. She clenched her fist and punched the crystal of the wall. The shining stone had no give, and pain reverberated to her

elbow. She did it again and again until her fingers were broken. It was going to be that kind of night.

Lifting her shredded hand to the heavens, she tried to summon her sword.

Nothing, not even a nascent flicker. Adora growled, then stopped and shook her head, resting her mind on the easiest image to draw She Ra forth: Catra looking down at her with wide, surprised eyes when the world was ending all around them. How they softened just before she leaned in and…

The blue flame descended upon her and erupted outward from her heart, making her form feel more solid. The injuries faded under the cooling waterfall of blue light.

Before the sword was broken, the transformation felt like it was achieved by the light taking her to pieces and then twisting her frame to its own preferences. Adora never told anyone how painful it was. She always thought that was the way of it, like sore muscles from lifting, shin splints from running, or growing pains when she shot up four inches in a year.

When she said the words, the sword became a live wire. Buzzing and crackling, her muscles contracted, locking her hand to the thing. She could not let go as it created a flaming circle around her. The muscles on her bones stretched to capacity, snapping, crunching, and then being remade. When she was able, she would drop the burning thing, clench her teeth, and pound one fist into another as she gasped, pushing down the screams. The hair bursting from her scalp felt like thousands of fire ants were biting her. Her head would snap backward as the magic crushed and reformed her. When she emerged from the transformation, she was pumped up with adrenaline, angry, frightened, and ready to fight. Prepared to kill or destroy.

When she first started training with Light Hope, the hologram ran her through drills, during which she rapidly transformed over and over. Light Hope was as implacable as any Horde instructor. She

remembered falling to the ground, whimpering with agony while Light Hope ordered, "Get up! Do it again, Adora," until she had passed out with exhaustion. She could transform in an instant, but that always hurt more than a slower transformation.

The transformation was so different now. On the deck of Prime's ship, as she held the dying Catra in her arms, a great magic river washed her pain and fear away. She remembered standing, calmly reaching out; the sword was in her hand. Heat rose from her core, and her heart overflowed. The new transformation was gentle. She was not stretched and remade; instead, she *unfurled.* The picture in her mind was the flower blossoms that Perfuma would speed grow, but they never screamed; they *sang.*

Melog sometimes chose to speak to Adora when she was She Ra; perhaps she would ask them about it. But now that the transformation was a gentle cascade rather than a brutal onslaught, she could not use the act to clear her head. That was why she was here, pounding walls

"Adora?" Mara's dark-haired, dark-eyed She Ra stood before her again

Fuck. Generally, the Castle took a minute before it started flinging holograms at her. "Go away," Adora grunted at the phantasm.

Wearily, she decided to go home. She turned to walk to where her skiff was parked, but Mara blocked the way. "No, Adora, listen. Don't you feel her? She's not happy with what you're doing. Can't you hear her?"

"Oh, for fuck's sake, *just stop* ." Adora cried, not wanting to hear what the stupid programming fragment had to say. Adora dropped the transformation and staggered sideways as the pain of all the no-longer-existent injuries crashed through her flesh and bone. She staggered to the entrance, made it to the skiff, and threw herself across the small craft's deck. This was fine. She could sleep here. Finally, she gave in to exhaustion, falling into a dead sleep on the floor of the skiff.

Much later, Adora woke up, feeling eyes upon her. She lifted her head to look around. The faintest hint of a hologram flickered to life just inside the castle’s entrance—a ghostly image of Mara, a remnant of the temple's ancient magic trying to offer guidance. Adora turned away. 'Not now,' she muttered, too weary for more ghosts or guilt, knowing it was only a dream. Without Light Hope, the Castle couldn’t spontaneously produce images without She Ra’s magic. When Adora withdrew the magic, the place was just rock.

Her last thoughts before sleep overtook her were of Catra, her anchor in every storm.

Echoes and clues

Chapter Summary

Adora gets home.

Catra asks questions

Chapter Notes

Thanks to Døc for the Beta-ing!

Also, a little slightly explicit smut. But only a little.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The skiff soared over the dense forests and rolling hills, the horizon bathed in the soft hues of early morning light. Adora gripped the controls tightly, her mind still foggy from a restless night in the temple.

She was so tired. Even as She Ra, her eyes were gritty, and if she dropped the transformation before she was safely home, she would surely nod off while she piloted her skiff. Falling from her skiff would be a stupid way to die—even if a part of her whispered that it would be a fate she deserved.

It was a good thing she had slept a few hours at the Crystal Castle. This was only a normal amount of exhaustion and would not be immediately discernable as a healing sleep, so Catra would not be as likely to worry.

Sleep was always difficult for Adora. Catra used to say her early risings were a symptom of her people-pleasing nature. It would be great if that were true. The truth was more complicated—Adora hated sleeping and fought it whenever she could. Many nights, she would lie awake, staring at the ceiling, her thoughts racing as she went over every mistake she ever made.

When she was a kid, she would go over the day trying to figure out how to better her scores. During the war, she analyzed and reanalyzed each battle, never considering the lives those battles claimed. Now, the guilt gnawed at her as she vividly pictured throwing tanks around.

Glimmer and Bow knew how hard it was for her to sleep alone when she first defected, but they did not know her ability to transform into She Ra masked the extent of her insomnia. Eventually, her body would demand rest, plunging her into a deep, dreamless sleep that felt more like a coma. But that was so much better than waking up alone in the middle of the night, her heart pounding out of her chest, brandishing the dagger she kept under her pillow at invisible monsters.

Only after breaking the Sword did Bow realize how little sleep Adora got. He'd see her at breakfast and remark on her tired appearance, urging her nightly to lie down and close her eyes. He never understood how excruciating it was for her to lie in the dark. Every rustle of leaves outside could be an approaching enemy, every flickering shadow a lurking threat.

Sleeping was easier now that Catra was back in her life. Adora never had to sleep alone. She trusted Catra's eyes in the dark, and she trusted Catra's ears to hear the slightest movement. With Catra purring beside her, she felt safe.

A tiny, guilty part of her reminded her that sleeping alone for the last few nights had been her choice. Adora had pushed Catra away, afraid of the nightmares and the turmoil in her head.

As the skiff approached Mystacor, Adora's heart lifted at the sight of the shimmering towers. Home. Where Catra was. She landed the skiff gently, the hum of its engine fading as she powered it down. The cool morning air embraced her as she stepped out, her boots clicking softly against the stone pathways in the early morning hush.

She made her way through the corridors, nodding at the few other early risers (or late sleepers) who were in the corridors. The weight of the night's fears and fatigue dissipated with every step closer to Catra. Adora used to think the romance books she borrowed from Bow were full of ridiculous metaphors—aching arms and describing sexual attraction as hunger or thirst—yet here she was. Her arms ached to hold Catra, and the feeling was so intense that it felt like hunger.

In the hallway, Adora paused, collecting herself before quietly pushing the door open. The faint, pleasant scent of their shared space greeted her, a mix of Catra's subtle musk and the floral notes of the soap they used. Catra sprawled across their bed, one arm flung over her eyes, her chest rising and falling with each steady breath. The familiar sight brought a smile to Adora's lips. Melog was absent, but they liked to take early walks.

Adora carefully changed into her night clothes. They were brand new—a gift from Aunt Casta—and their softness felt like an unearned indulgence. Adora slowly crawled into bed beside her wife, trying not to wake her. But Catra stirred, her eyes fluttering open.

"Adora?" Catra's voice was groggy but concerned. "You're early. What time is it? Did something happen?"

Adora wrapped her arms around her, resting her forehead against Catra's. "Nothing happened. I just… I couldn't sleep. I needed to be with you."

Catra's eyes softened, and something tight and raw inside Adora's chest began to unwind. The knots of fear and tension eased with each purr as Catra tucked herself under Adora's chin.

"Bad night?" Catra whispered into Adora's shoulder. "Nightmare?"

"Yeah."

"Same one?"

"No," Adora said. The unease from her encounter with Mara's hologram lingered, but she pushed it aside. "I don't really remember it."

Catra backed off and studied her face with narrowed eyes. "But it was bad enough for you to head back from Salineas in the middle of the night?"

Adora cursed inwardly, having forgotten she was supposed to be in Salineas. "Well, maybe it was because I missed my wife." She nuzzled into Catra's neck and put her arm around her waist, pressing kisses under the magicat's jaw.

Catra giggled, a little squeak escaping at the end. "You big dork."

Adora started nibbling along Catra's throat. "Is this all right?" she asked, always careful.

Catra gasped but didn't pull away. "Yeah. That… um… that's just fine."

Adora's hand drifted to the hem of Catra's shirt. "Can I?" She looked into Catra's half-lidded eyes.

Catra licked her lips and nodded, pulling off the shirt herself before lying back. In the morning light, her hair glowed golden around her face and ears. Adora knelt on the bed, petting Catra's fluffy stomach.

Catra sucked in a sharp breath and squirmed, making Adora smile. "You like that?" she asked.

Instead of answering verbally, Catra propped herself up on one elbow, hooking her arm around Adora's neck and pulling her in for a kiss before dropping back and nodding.

It wasn't often Adora saw Catra so relaxed and vulnerable. She petted a long stroke between the underside of Catra's breast and the crease where her thigh met her hip. Catra shivered, her eyes locked on Adora's face, pupils round, mouth serious.

Adora hovered her hand over Catra's breast. "Is this okay?" she asked, slowly placing her palm on the soft mound.

"Yeah," whispered Catra, her eyes darting away shyly.

Adora's fingers brushed against Catra's nipple, feeling it stiffen.

"Oh!" Catra's eyes closed as she arched into Adora's hand, tipping her head back.

"You are so beautiful," Adora whispered, leaning over Catra, propped on one hand. "Tell me what you want."

Catra's eyes rolled open, her pupils huge and round. "You," she breathed. Her cheeks were red beneath the peachfuzz of her face. Then, her expression shifted. Instead of soft and hopeful, her smile was hungry and demanding. Catra pulled Adora down for a kiss and ran her hand up Adora's ribs, making her shiver. Catra's tongue swiped against Adora's lips. For a half second, Adora resisted, but then she opened them with a little whimper. Catra's slightly rough tongue felt strange and tickly as she licked into Adora's mouth. She slipped her hands under Adora's shirt.

Feeling Catra's hand on her back, skin to skin, made something deep in Adora's stomach tighten. Her chest went cold, and she stiffened. She wanted to pull back. A voice in her head was screaming, but she could not understand the words. Her throat tightened as she held in the sudden urge to sob.

"You okay?" Catra asked, putting her ears back and obviously picking up on the change.

Adora was not okay—not in the least. A panicky freeze took over her limbs, and she opened her mouth to say something but came up empty. Catra's hand was hot under her shirt, pressing against her shoulder blade. Why did she expect Catra's hand to be cold? It was just Catra-- Adora was never afraid of Catra. She had always respected Catra as an opponent in battle and had feared what she could do, but she had never truly feared *her* . At least, not like this.

This was a completely different kind of fear. This kind of fear made Adora want to find some dark hole to hide in. She wanted to close her eyes and block her ears. She remembered curling up just like that under the basement stairs when… When..?

When? When what? When was what happening? It was there and then gone. Something important. Adora blinked, disoriented. What was going on?

Catra backed off to see Adora's face, and a crease formed between her eyebrows. "Adora? Hey, look at me," she whispered.

Finally, the hand on Adora's back withdrew, and she could breathe again. She tried to cover her discomfort with a nervous smile. "I guess I…" she trailed off, not knowing what to say. She sat up, suddenly feeling like she needed a shower. Her weird freeze-up was passing, but she felt a loss as if some part of her was missing. Worse, she had ruined the mood." I-I guess I'm more tired than I thought," Adora said lamely. "It was a long ride." She started to stand. "I'm kinda gross, I should…"

Catra's hand caught Adora's wrist, making her stop and meet her wife's worried gaze. "It's fine," Catra said gently. When had Catra gotten so patient? "You haven't slept, have you?"

If Adora *had* been coming back from Salineas, she *would* have been up all night, so it felt safe to admit it. "No, not really. Just an hour in the skiff when I got too tired." Catra did not need to know she had to transform to get home.

"Come here," Catra said, gently pulling her back into bed. She arranged them so that they lay on their sides. Catra pulled Adora's arm around her waist so that they were chest-to-chest, with Catra's naked breasts pressed against the fabric of Adora's thin nightshirt. She pulled the sheet over them. "This better?" Catra asked. "We can take this up later when you're not, like ready to pass out from exhaustion, okay?"

Adora nodded, perhaps a bit too eagerly, ready to be done with this conversation.

That's right. You see? It doesn't hurt if you don't fight me.

Catra nodded and leaned forward to kiss Adora's temple, her touch grounding and soothing. "Get some rest. I'm here."

Catra was right. Sleep would fix this. Sleep always fixed this feeling.

There now, my dear. Run along to your bunk. It was just a dream.

"Catra?" Adora whispered, her voice sounding a little too high.

Her wife cracked open her amber eye. "Yeah?"

"I love you." It felt urgent that she said it, and Catra deserved to hear it.

The soft purring kicked up a notch, and Catra smiled. "I love you too."

And that was the important thing, wasn't it? Worn out by the storm of her emotions, Adora drifted into a warm half-sleep. The vibration of Catra's purr provided proof they were safe. Catra would sense any danger long before Adora did.

With Catra's comforting presence, Adora felt the tension in her body slowly dissolve. She closed her eyes, letting herself drift off, knowing she was safe.

Catra stared at the bloody leggings in her hand, the black spots stark against the fabric, trying to figure out why they were making her brain itch. She had kept them for some reason, even though the enormous hole in the knee probably was not worth repairing. She thought she tossed them out last week, but here they were, in the bottom of the hamper again.

"That is your mate's blood," Melog confirmed with a sniff.

"Yeah…" Catra said slowly, unsure why a chill crept up her spine. Something about this was very wrong.

Something in her brain clicked.

"Wait a minute." She walked over to the closet where she and Adora hung their clothes. On one hanger was Adora's stupid jacket. It looked brand new, even though Adora had worn it all day, every day, for the better part of three years.

"Why is her stupid jacket in such good condition?" she asked Melog.

"It is probably due to her transformation," the alien cat replied.

Catra frowned, processing this. "The same transformation that fixes her injuries?" she asked rhetorically, her mind bubbling with implications. "The same one she does when she wants to skip showering or changing?"

Melog tilted their head like one of her instructors waiting for an answer in tactics class.

"So, why didn't her magic work on this?" Catra held up the leggings, and a knot of dread formed in her stomach. She hoped Melog had an answer that was not as horrible as the ones going through her mind.

"Maybe she did not transform while she wore them?"

That made for one hell of an image. It made Catra grin briefly, although her humor was strained. "I think folks around here would lose their minds if Adora went running without any pants."

"The Protector has only just awoken, Granddaughter. Perhaps it is Her doing?"

Startled out of her reverie, Catra jerked her head up to look straight at Melog. "Who?"

Melog slowly blinked at her. That was not reassuring; they sometimes did that when they had something to say that Catra would not like.

"The Protector." An image of She Ra's silhouette appeared in Catra's mind's eye. Her face was featureless, and she glowed golden. She had Adora's ponytail and hair poof and held the Sword upraised in her hand.

"Wait… I thought the Protector... I mean, I thought She Ra *was* Adora?" Catra demanded.

"Yes and no." Melog paused as though thinking how to word things. Sometimes, they could just push information into Catra's head, but complex ideas needed explanation. "Your Mate is a host for the Protector spirit bound to the Sword." Melog projected the image of the featureless She Ra melting into Adora, creating the transformation. "I have not spoken to Her, but I know She has been uneasy of late."

"Wait. Are you telling me magic has *opinions* ?" Catra squawked indignantly.

The end of Melog's tail twitched. "Of course," they said blandly as if Catra had just told them what color the sky was.

"Adora has something else living in her head?" Catra exclaimed, trying to be clear.

"Yes." Melog seemed unbothered by this idea. "But The Protector slumbered while bound to the Sword. I feel She has been awakening to forge a proper bond with her host. But, it feels as though She is displeased."

Catra's mind raced, turning the idea over. "Okay, so if She Ra is feeling pissy at Adora, why the leggings? Why leave them like that? It's just irritating."

"I think, perhaps she seeks aid from Your Mate's friends and family?"

"Well, does it have to be so damned cryptic? Couldn't she just, I don't know, leave a fucking note?"

"Goddesses are not known for their straightforward communication," Melog observed wryly. "Imagine you are trying to communicate with an insect. What would you say to them?"

Okay, yeah. Point.

"If she were trying to convey that something was wrong, these little marks of inconsistency might be the best she can do."

"Like Sparkles and Arrow Boy could pick up on anything." That was not fair. Catra knew that, but she was angry on Adora's behalf. Mostly at herself because Adora had been acting weird for weeks and was getting steadily more bizarre, and none of them had called her on it.

"So, what should I do?" Catra asked. She could confront Adora, but…

"You believe if you confront her, she will likely become better at hiding?" Melog finished for her.

Catra sighed. "Yeah. Or, it's totally innocent, and I would just look like a paranoid asshole." She certainly did not want to become the kind of wife who needed to control her partner's every movement.

"Perhaps more evidence is necessary to understand what is happening?"

"Yeah. That makes sense." Something occurred to Catra. "You know, all the Horde's skiffs have tracking software."

Adora was out on a late afternoon run, so Catra wandered out to check on the skiff, taking her tracker pad. She left a note that she would be back by supper in case Adora got home early. Flipping

the power switch on, she looked for the trip log app on the computer. She wasn't sure that Adora even knew this was a thing—the day they had gone on a joyride on that skiff, she certainly did not seem to know.

The data was not where it was supposed to be.

Wait. *Could* Adora have known?

Catra scrolled through the system, only to find that the mapping, trip history, and tracking had been disabled in the settings. Well, that was going to be a pain.

Catra dialed Entrapta's access code.

"Hi, Catra!" Entrapta chirped from the other end. "I was just about to call you!"

"Yeah?"

"The new portal is ready, and I want to test it as soon as possible!"

"Portal? What?" Catra sputtered. What the actual fuck was she talking about?

"You know, the one we were texting about last week? So yeah, I figured we wanted to test it before we showed it to Micah. And if Melog can… "

Catra's head swiveled to glare at Melog. "Melog. Right. That text conversation."

Melog did not even have the grace to look embarrassed. "You were busy," they chirped. "And I did not realize the Technomancer would have something ready so quickly."

Yeah, that made sense. Melog had been visiting with Micah for an hour or two every day for the last week. If Melog felt that

Entrapta could help, there was no reason why they should not talk to her.

"Okay, tell me again what we agreed to?" One nice thing about Entrapta was that she never questioned when Catra wanted her to go over things again.

"Well, we're going to use the portal to find Angella. Melog can find her by following Micah and Glimmer's empathic bond to her, and then we will send you through the portal to get her."

"Remind me again, why me?" Catra asked. Sadly, knowing Entrapta, there was a solid reason behind it.

"Because you suggested it. Melog said they can always find you if you get lost or something. Were you not paying attention?"

Catra rolled her eyes and then glared at Melog. "Ooo-kay. Right."

That was all. Just hop into a pocket dimension. Easy-peasy.

"I just wanted to make sure we're all on the same page. So you want to do this tomorrow?" Catra asked carefully.

"Oh, no! We need to test it first! Can you and Melog be here in the morning?"

Adora mentioned that she wanted to start decommissioning the Crystal Castle tomorrow, so she would be gone all day anyway.

"Yeah, okay." She looked down at the console of the skiff. "Hey, I think my skiff's computer is messed up. All my log data is lost. Like for the past couple of weeks. Can you still get it?"

"Hmm. Maybe." Entrapta paused as someone in the background spoke. "Oh! Right!" Entrapta said to whoever it was. "You know what! There was a glitchy update a few weeks ago that was giving some people calibration problems. It's been patched, so just turn the computer off, turn it on again, and let it update. I bet the logs will pop right back up. Anyway, see you tomorrow?"

Catra sighed. "Yeah, okay." She could get Adora to drop her off at the Fright Zone on her way to the Crystal Castle. It was almost on the way.

She leaned down under the console to hit the "hard reboot" switch and flipped it. She counted to one hundred. Then she turned it back on. The little screen glowed blue with the round loading symbol. Underneath, it said, "1% updated. Estimated time for update: 4 hours."

Catra huffed an irritated sigh. She would have to wait to see the logs to determine if it was just a glitchy update or if Adora had suddenly become competent with machinery.

Her head full of questions, Catra meandered upstairs to meet her wife for supper.

Chapter End Notes

This story continues in Swapsies.

Works inspired by this one

[Restricted Work] by Quiet_Ninja_Kitty

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